

“After the [Russian] revolution of 1917, the Bolshevik regime became the first government in history to declare that women’s emancipation was one of its primary goals and to write it into law. Legislation ensuring equal pay for equal work was instantly [passed], and women’s right (if not their obligation) to work became central to Soviet notions of citizenship. Yet, after the first fifteen years of Soviet rule, it was evident that the Leninist ideal of freeing women...was still a distant utopia. In retrospect it was also evident that the Soviet Union’s commitment to women’s equal employment has never been purely ideological and has been based rather on pragmatic, demographic factors: rapid economic growth, labor shortages, and a frequent shortage of males.

In the past decade [the 1980s], the average female worker, although she was slightly better educated than her male counterpart, earned only two-thirds as much as the average male.... Some forty percent of Soviet working women are employed in unskilled manual labor or low-skilled industrial work.

The higher professions are equally unbalanced. About three-quarters of the schoolteachers but only about a third of the school principals are women. Some seventy percent of the doctors are women, but more than half the hospital administrators are men and [they] are in charge of formulating local health policy. The inequality is even more striking among engineers and skilled technical workers.”

Source: Francine du Plessix Gray, French-American journalist, *Soviet Women: Walking the Tightrope*, 1990

1. Respond to parts A, B, and C.

- A. Describe the main argument made by the author in the excerpt.
- B. Describe one piece of evidence used by the author in the excerpt to support her argument.
- C. Explain how one historical development in the second half of the 1900s likely influenced the author’s perspective.